

Marathi, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Marathi one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Devanagari letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read नमस्कार *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. (A reader who already reads Devanagari simply skims the letter notes — “the letters in this word” in the earlier chapters, “sounds you’ll need” in the later ones.)

Marathi is written in Devanagari, the script of Hindi and Sanskrit — but it is its own **Indo-Aryan** language, the tongue of Maharashtra, and one shaped by long contact with the Dravidian south. So the book keeps two contrasts in view: Marathi’s Sanskrit inheritance (shared with Hindi), and the ways it goes its own way — an extra letter ष, *three* grammatical genders where Hindi kept two, and gender marked on the *verb*. Roots are traced to Sanskrit and, where they reach, to the wider Indo-European family that also gave English its words — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any other language is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Marathi out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

The Marathi greetings — and, taught through them, how to read the Devanagari script and what makes Marathi its own language, not a dialect of Hindi. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs. *Practice lessons: lessons/MR-C01-*.md.*

1.1 नमस्कार (*namaskār*) — “greetings”

The letters in this word

(If you already read Devanagari, skim this.) Devanagari runs **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” न na, म ma, का kā, र ra. The stroke under स् (a *halant*) removes its vowel, so the bare *s* leans onto the next as a conjunct: स् + का → स्का. Read न·म·स्·का·र → *namaskār*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नमस्कार (*namaskār*) = नमः (*namaḥ*, “a bow”) + कार (*kāra*, “the making of”), from Sanskrit — literally “the making of a bow.” It is the *same* word Kannada and Telugu borrowed, and close kin to Hindi’s *namaskār*. But note: where Hindi leans on *namaste*, Marathi’s everyday, all-purpose greeting is **namaskār** — one of many small ways the two Devanagari languages differ.

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together, respectful and neutral — it serves as both hello and goodbye, morning to night, to almost anyone. Warmer

and more casual is a simple *kāy mhṇtā?* (“what do you say?,” i.e. “how’s it going?”), for friends.

1.2 धन्यवाद (*dhanyavād*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

New: ध *dha* (a breathy *d*), य *ya*, वा *vā*, द *da*, and the conjunct न्य (*na + ya*). Read ध·न्य·वा·द → *dhanyavād*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

धन्यवाद (*dhanyavād*) = Sanskrit *dhanya* (“worthy”) + *vāda* (“a saying”) — “an utterance of ‘[you are] worthy.’” The same Sanskrit word behind Hindi *dhanyavād*, Kannada *dhanyavāda*, Telugu *dhanyavādamulu*. Warmer, more spoken Marathi often says आभारी आहे (*ābhārī āhe*, “[I am grateful]”), on the root *ābhār*, “gratitude.”

1.3 हो (*ho*) — “yes”

The letters in this word

ह (*ha*) + the *o*-mātrā ो → हो (*ho*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

हो (*ho*, “yes”) is the plain affirmative — distinct from Hindi’s *hāmī*. Marathi builds its own everyday words on shared Indo-Aryan roots. The polite, fuller “yes” is *ho, baṇ āhe* (“yes, it’s fine”).

1.4 नाही (*nāhī*) — “no”

The letters in this word

ना (*nā*) + ही (*hī*) → *nāhī*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नाही (*nāhī*, “no / is not”) sits on the ancient negative *na-* — the *same* Proto-Indo-European **ne* behind English **no**, **not**, **none**, Latin *non*, and Hindi *nahīṇ*. It doubles as “there isn’t”: Marathi, like Hindi, denies with this one word.

1.5 बरं (*barṇ*) — “okay, fine”

The letters in this word

ब (*ba*) + रं (*ra* with the *anusvāra* dot ँ, a light nasal) → *barṇ*. That dot on top nasalises the vowel.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

बरं (*barṇ*, “okay, fine, good, all right”) is the verbal shrug of Marathi — a soft “sure, fine,” the oil of everyday talk (its neutral form is *barē*). It is a genuinely Marathi word, not a Sanskrit loan.

1.6 येतो / येते (*yeto* / *yete*) — “I’ll take my leave”

The letters in this word

ये (*ye*) + तो (*to*) → *yeto*; ये + ते (*te*) → *yete*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Marathi, like the Dravidian languages to its south, will not say a bare “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is येतो (*yeto*) — literally “I **come** [again],” a promise of return, never a final departure. (Fuller: *yeto*, *namaskār*.)

Grammar Lens

Marathi verbs carry gender. *yeto* is what a *man* says; a *woman* says येते (*yete*). The verb itself changes with the speaker’s gender — something Hindi does only in the past tense, but Marathi does in the present too. (And Marathi keeps *three* genders — masculine, feminine, and neuter — where Hindi kept only two.) You’ll meet this again at

every verb.

1.7 Recap

Marathi		Meaning
नमस्कार	<i>namaskār</i>	hello / goodbye
धन्यवाद	<i>dhanyavād</i>	thank you
हो	<i>ho</i>	yes
नाही	<i>nāhī</i>	no
बरं	<i>barṇ</i>	okay / fine
येतो / येते	<i>yeto / yete</i>	“I’ll be going” (m./f.)

Marathi is written in Devanagari like Hindi, but it is its own Indo-Aryan language: it prefers *namaskār*, keeps **three** genders, marks **gender on the verb** (*yeto/yete*), and — as the reference page shows — has an extra letter, ऌ (ḷa), that Hindi lacks. Next chapter: introducing yourself — *mājhe nāv...* (“my name...”) — and Marathi’s *tū / tumhī* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you are glad to meet them:

माझं नाव मीरा आहे. (*mājhṃ nāv Mīra āhe* — “My name is Mira.”)
तुमचं नाव काय आहे? (*tumchṃ nāv kāy āhe* — “What is your name?”)

Practice lessons: lessons/MR-C02-.md.*

2.1 नाव (*nāv*) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The letters in this word

ना (*nā*) + व (*va*) → नाव *nāv*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

नाव (*nāv*) ← Sanskrit नामन् (*nāman*, “name”). Watch the small Marathi shift: the Sanskrit *-m-* softened to *-v-*, so *nām* became **nāv** (Hindi kept the *m*: *nām*). That *nāman* goes back to PIE **h₃nómn*. — the same root as English **name** and **noun**, Latin *nōmen*, Greek *onoma*. A cousin from before either language existed.

Grammar Lens

A Marathi habit: soft consonants. *m*→*v* here is one of many softening shifts that distinguish Marathi from Hindi. Spot the shift and a Sanskrit word reads straight into Marathi.

2.2 माझं (*mājhṇ*) — “my,” and gender again

The letters in this word

मा (*mā*) + झं (*jha* with the *anusvāra* ँ) → *mājhṇ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

माझं (*mājhṇ*, “my”) sits on the first-person root *ma-* — the same root behind English **me**, **my**, **mine**, Latin *meus*, Hindi *merā*.

Grammar Lens

“My” agrees in three genders. माझा (*mājhā*, m.) / माझी (*mājhī*, f.) / माझं (*mājhṇ*, n.). The noun *nāṇ* (“name”) is **neuter**, so “my name” is *mājhṇ nāṇ*. You met this gender idea already in the goodbye *yeto/yete*; it runs through the whole language.

2.3 आहे (*āhe*) — “is,” and it comes last

The letters in this word

आ (*ā*, the standalone long-*ā* vowel) + हे (*he*) → आहे *āhe*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

आहे (*āhe*, “is”) descends from Sanskrit अस्ति (*ásti*), on the root √*as* (“to be”). That √*as* / PIE **h₁es-* is the ancestor of Latin *est*, German *ist*, and English **is** itself — the oldest verb in the family, worn to *āhe* in Marathi.

Grammar Lens

The verb goes last. Marathi is subject–object–verb: “my name Mira *is*.” *āhe* sits at the end, and it changes with the subject — *mī āhe* (I am), *tū āhes* (you are), *tumhī āhāt* (you are, resp.), which you will use in the next chapter.

2.4 माझं नाव ...आहे — “my name is...”

माझं (my) + नाव (name) + आहे (is) = “my name is...” *Mājhm̐ nāv Arun āhe*. The *mājhm̐* is neuter to agree with *nāv*; the verb comes last.

2.5 तू / तुम्ही (*tū* / *tumhī*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

तू (*tū*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit त्वम् (*tvam*), PIE **tū* — the root of English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, French *tu*, Hindi *tū*. तुम्ही (*tumhī*, respectful) is grammatically **plural** — honouring one person as many, exactly like French *vous*; it takes the plural copula *āhāt*.

Grammar Lens

A choice of respect, every time. *tū* for a friend or child; *tumhī* for an elder, a stranger, anyone you show courtesy to. Marathi makes you pick with each address.

2.6 काय (*kāy*) — “what”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

काय (*kāy*, “what”) grows from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE **k^wo-* — the root behind English **wh-** words and Latin *qu-*. Marathi keeps the *k-* plainly across its questions: *kāy* (what), *koṇ* (who), *kuṭhe* (where), *kā* (why), *kaśm̐* (how). Hear that opening *k-* and a question is coming.

2.7 तुमचं नाव काय आहे? — “what’s your name?”

तुमचं (*tumchm̐*, “your,” neuter to match *nāv*) + नाव + काय (what) + आहे (is) = “your name what is?”, verb last. The “your” set mirrors the “my” set: *mājhm̐* (my) / *tumchm̐* (your, resp.) / *tujhm̐* (your, familiar) — all neuter here before *nāv*. To a friend: तुझं नाव काय आहे? (*tujhm̐ nāv kāy āhe?*).

2.8 भेटून आनंद झाला (*bheṭūn ānand jhālā*) — “a joy to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is भेटून आनंद झाला — literally “having met [you], joy happened.” आनंद (*ānand*, “joy, bliss”) is **Sanskrit** — *ā-* (“fully”) + *nand* (“to rejoice”) — the *ānanda* of *sat-cit-ānanda* and a common given name. And *bheṭūn* is built on भेटणे (*bheṭṇe*, “to meet”), the verb behind Chapter 4’s *punhā bheṭū*.

2.9 The whole exchange

Marathi	English
माझं नाव मीरा आहे.	My name is Mira.
तुमचं नाव काय आहे?	What’s your name?
माझं नाव अरुण आहे.	My name is Arun.
भेटून आनंद झाला.	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *nāv* ($\rightarrow$ *name*), *mājhm̐* ($\rightarrow$ *my*), *kāy* ($\rightarrow$ *what*), *tū* ($\rightarrow$ *thou*). And two Marathi distinctives came back: three genders (on *mājhm̐*) and the verb *āhe* going **last**. Next chapter: *tumhā kase āhāt?* (“how are you?”).

Chapter 3

How Are You?

The everyday exchange after hello:

तुम्ही कसे आहात? (*tumhī kase āhāt* — “How are you?”)
मी बरा आहे, धन्यवाद. (*mī barā āhe, dhanyavād* — “I’m well, thank you.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/MR-C03-.md.*

3.1 कसा / कशी / कसं (*kasā / kaśī / kaṣṇ*) — “how”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

कसा (*kasā*, “how”) is another *k-* question, from PIE **k^wo-* — the root behind English **how** (a *wh-* word that lost its *w*) and Latin *quo-modo* (“in what way,” → Spanish *cómo*).

Grammar Lens

“How” agrees with whom you ask. कसा (*kasā*, to a man) / कशी (*kaśī*, to a woman) / कसं (*kaṣṇ*, neuter). So “how are you?” shifts shape with the person addressed.

3.2 तुम्ही कसे आहात? — “how are you?”

तुम्ही (*tumhī*, resp. “you”) + कसे (*kase*, “how,” plural-agreeing) + आहात (*āhāt*, “are,” resp.) = “you how are?”, verb last. Because *tumhī* is grammatically plural, “how” appears as *kase* and the copula as *āhāt*. To a male friend: तू कसा आहेस? (*tū kasā āhes?*); to a female friend: तू कशी आहेस? (*tū kaśī āhes?*).

3.3 मी (*mī*) — “I”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

मी (*mī*, “I”) descends from Sanskrit अहम् (*aham*), worn down to *mī*. That *aham* is PIE **h₁eg(H)om* — the ancestor of Latin **ego** and English **I**. Note its family tie to last chapter’s *mājhm* (“my”): the same first-person *m*- thread, as English pairs *I* with *me/my*.

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“I am” is *mī āhe*. And “I’m fine” reaches back to Chapter 1’s *barṃ* in its gendered form: *mī barā āhe* (a man) / *mī barī āhe* (a woman).

3.4 मी बरा आहे — “I’m well, thank you”

मी (I) + बरा (*barā*, “well”) + आहे (*am*) = “I am well.” Chapter 1’s *barṃ* was the bare **neuter** “okay”; describing a person it takes their gender: *barā* (m.) / *barī* (f.). Add thanks: *mī barā āhe*, *dhanyavād*.

Grammar Lens

The copula changes with the subject. *mī āhe* (I am), *tū āhes* (you are), *tumhī āhāt* (you are, resp.) — one verb, reshaped for each person. Marathi marks *who* on the verb itself.

3.5 काही हरकत नाही (*kāhī harkat nāhī*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

काही (*kāhī*, “any”) + हरकत (*harkat*, “objection”) + नाही (*nāhī*, “not”) = “[there is] no objection at all” — Marathi’s easy “you’re welcome / no problem.” Two histories meet: *nāhī* rides PIE **ne* (English **no**, **not**), while *harkat* is a **Perso-Arabic** loan (Arabic *ḥarakah*) — one of the many Persian and Arabic words Marathi absorbed under the Decan sultanates. An Indo-European negative wrapped around an Arabic noun.

3.6 The whole exchange

Marathi	English
तुम्ही कसे आहात?	How are you?
मी बरा आहे, धन्यवाद.	I'm well, thank you.
काही हरकत नाही.	No problem / you're welcome.

Roots banked: *kasā* (the *k*- questions, gender-agreeing), *mī* (*aham* → Latin *ego*, English *I*), *barā/barī* (now gendered), *harkat* (Arabic, the Deccan trade-and-court layer). Next chapter: the farewells — *punhā bhetū*.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Chapter 1 gave you the quick येतो (*yeto*, “I’ll come again”). Its explicit companion:

पुन्हा भेटू! (*punhā bheṭū* — “We’ll meet again!”)

Practice lessons: lessons/MR-CO4-.md.*

4.1 पुन्हा (*punhā*) — “again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

पुन्हा (*punhā*, “again, back”) is from Sanskrit पुनर् (*punar*, “again”), a cousin of Latin *re-* (“back/again”) and the *puna-* of *punarjanma* (“re-birth”). To say a thing *punhā* is to send it round once more.

4.2 भेटू (*bheṭū*) — “(we’ll) meet”

The letters in this word

भे (*bhe*) + टू (*ṭū*, the retroflex ट *ṭa* with the long-*u*) → *bheṭū*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

भेटू (*bheṭū*) is a form of भेटणे (*bheṭṇe*, “to meet”), a native Marathi verb (the stem *bheṭ-* also gives *bheṭ*, “a meeting”). As *bheṭū* it means “let’s / we’ll meet” — the hopeful mood a goodbye wants.

Grammar Lens

“We” lives in the verb. *bheṭū* carries its own “we/let’s” in the *-ū* ending — no separate word for “we” needed. Unlike the present (*yeto/yete*), this future-wish form does *not* split by gender.

4.3 पुन्हा भेटू — “see you again”

पुन्हा (again) + भेटू (we’ll meet) = “we’ll meet again” — the explicit twin of Chapter 1’s *yeto*. Stack them for warmth: येतो, पुन्हा भेटू (*yeto, punhā bheṭū*). Neither word says “goodbye”; the parting is all return (Hindi *phir milenge*, Bengali *āshi*, Tamil *pōy varugirēṇ*).

4.4 उद्या भेटू (*udyā bheṭū*) — “see you tomorrow”**The word, taken apart — its roots and family**

उद्या (*udyā*, “tomorrow”) + भेटू (we’ll meet) = “we’ll meet tomorrow.” Unlike Hindi *kal* (which means *both* tomorrow and yesterday), Marathi keeps them apart: *udyā* (tomorrow) vs. काल (*kāl*, yesterday). The verb carries the future; the first word sets the day.

4.5 काळजी घ्या (*kālījī ghyā*) — “take care”**The letters in this word**

काळजी carries ळ (*la*), the **retroflex “l”** Marathi keeps (Hindi dropped it): का+ळ+जी → *kālījī*. Then घ्या (*ghyā*, “take,” resp.).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

काळजी (*kālījī*, “care, concern”) + घ्या (*ghyā*, “take”) = “take care.” Where *punhā bheṭū* looks to the next meeting, this looks after the person in between — “mind yourself until then.” The respectful घ्या (*ghyā*) matches *tumhā*; to a friend, काळजी घे (*kālījī ghe*), matching *tū*.

4.6 The farewells

Marathi	English
येतो / येते.	I'll be going. (“come again”)
पुन्हा भेटू.	See you again.
उद्या भेटू.	See you tomorrow.
काळजी घ्या.	Take care.

Roots banked: *punhā* (*punar* “again”), *bhetṇe* (“to meet”; “we” in the ending), *udyā* (tomorrow, kept apart from *kāl* yesterday), *kāl̥jī* (the retroflex ळ). Every Marathi goodbye is a **return** or a caring wish — never a bare “farewell.” Next chapter: the first real verbs — *mī marāṭhī bolto*.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, verbs of *being* and *meeting*. Now verbs that *act* — and sentences that move:

मी मराठी बोलतो. (*mī marāṭhī bolto* — “I speak Marathi.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/MR-C05-.md.*

5.1 बोलणे (*bolṇe*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

बो (*bo*) + ल (*la*) + णे (*ṇe*, the **retroflex** ण *ṇa*) → *bolṇe*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

बोलणे (*bolṇe*, “to speak”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb on the stem *bol-* (the same *bol-* as Hindi *bolnā*, Punjabi *bolṇā*). Its ending -णे (*-ṇe*) is Marathi’s **infinitive**: *bol-ṇe* “to speak,” *bheṭ-ṇe* “to meet,” *ye-ṇe* “to come.” Strip *-ṇe* for the stem (*bol-*).

Grammar Lens

Stem + gendered present ending. *mī bolto* (a man speaks) / *mī bolte* (a woman speaks) — the present tense splits by the speaker’s gender, as *yeto/yete* did. And it needs **no** separate “am”: the one word does the work, at the end of the sentence.

5.2 मी मराठी बोलतो — “I speak Marathi”

मी (I) + मराठी (*marāṭhī*, the object) + बोलतो (speak) — “I Marathi speak,” verb last (a woman: *mī marāṭhī bolte*). The name मराठी is “[the language] of महाराष्ट्र (*Mahārāṣṭra*)” — the “great realm,” *mahā* (“great,” cousin of Latin *magnus*, English *magnitude*) + *rāṣṭra* (“nation”). People *Marāṭhā*, land *Mahārāṣṭra*, tongue *marāṭhī* — one root.

5.3 राहणे (*rāhṇe*) — “to live, to stay”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

राहणे (*rāhṇe*, “to live, remain”) is from Sanskrit *rah-* (“to remain,” the same root as Hindi *rahnā*): *mī puṇyāt rāhto* (“I live in Pune”).

Grammar Lens

“In” comes after the noun. पुण्यात (*puṇyāt*) = पुणे (*Puṇe*, the city) + *-āt* (“in”), glued to the noun’s *end*. Marathi uses **postpositions**, verb last.

5.4 काम करणे (*kām karṇe*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

करणे (*karṇe*, “to do, make”) is from Sanskrit $\sqrt{kr}$ (“to do”), PIE $*k^{av}er-$ — the very root inside Chapter 1’s नमस्कार (*namaskār* = “the *making* of a bow”) and कर्म (*karma*, “a thing *done*”). And काम (*kām*, “work”) is itself worn down from that *karma*. Marathi builds compounds as **noun** + करणे: काम करणे (*kām karṇe*, “work-do” = “to work”), *madat karṇe* (“to help”). Present, gendered: *mī kām karto/karte* (“I work”).

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Marathi	English
मी मराठी बोलतो / बोलते.	I speak Marathi.
मी पुण्यात राहतो / राहते.	I live in Pune.
मी काम करतो / करते.	I work.

One engine: an infinitive in *-ṇe*; a present of stem + a **gendered** ending (*-to* m. / *-te* f.) that folds in the “am”; the verb last; “in” on the noun’s tail. Roots banked: *bolṇe* (native), *marāṭhī* ($\leftarrow$ *Mahārāṣṭra* “great realm”), *rāhṇe* (*rah-* “remain”), *karṇe* ($\sqrt{kr}$ — root of *namaskār*, *karma*; *kām* $\leftarrow$ *karma*). From here, Marathi only opens further.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

6.1 एक, दोन, तीन, चार, पाच — one to five

Marathi and Hindi both use Devanagari and both descend from Sanskrit, so their numbers look almost identical. **Almost** is where the interest is.

You'll want to know: the five

	Marathi	said
1	एक	<i>ek</i>
2	दोन	<i>don</i>
3	तीन	<i>tīn</i>
4	चार	<i>chār</i> — but see below
5	पाच	<i>pāch</i>

What you've built: three Marathi tells

Set them against Hindi. Two differences are visible and one is audible:

number	Hindi	Marathi
2	दो <i>do</i>	दोन <i>don</i> : final <i>n</i>
5	पाँच <i>pāñch</i>	पाच <i>pāch</i> : no nasal mark
4	चार <i>chār</i>	चार <i>tsār</i> : same spelling, different sound

Do not explain all three histories yet. First make the five forms automatic; the next lesson earns the deeper comparison.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ek, don, tīn, tsār, pāch”
- the visible tells — *don* has *n*; *pāch* has no nasal mark
- the audible tell — written *chār*, Marathi *tsār*

Before you move on

Count to five in Marathi. (*Ek, don, tīn, tsār, pāch.*) Where does Marathi add a letter compared with Hindi? (दोन, *don.*) Which form drops a nasal mark? (पाच, *pāch.*) What differs in चार without differing in spelling? (Marathi’s च is nearer **ts** before *ā*.) Next: explain where those differences came from.

6.2 Why Marathi *two* rhymes with *three*

Count once: *ek, don, tīn, tsār, pāch.* Which two words end in *n*? (*Don* and *tīn.*)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The tempting guess is that Marathi दोन *don* kept something Hindi दो *do* lost. It did not.

Sanskrit’s neuter word for three, त्रीणि *trīṇi*, became Prakrit **tiṇṇi**. In *three*, the **ṇ** genuinely belongs to the word. The doubled consonant is a Prakrit trade for the lost *r*.

The word for two was then reshaped to match its neighbour: Prakrit **doṇṇi** copied the shape of **tiṇṇi**. Marathi *don*’s final *n* is therefore an **innovation**, a rhyme borrowed from the number next door. Hindi *do* simply never took it.

English numbers did this too: *four* acquired its initial *f*- by analogy with *five*. Familiar sequences pull neighbouring words toward one another.

What you’ve built: पाच and the nasal Hindi kept

Marathi पाच *pāch* and Hindi पाँच *pāñch* tell the opposite story. Hindi’s chandrabindu ँ records the nasal of Sanskrit *pañca*; Marathi’s spelling drops it.

So neither language is simply “older.” Marathi innovated in *don*, while Hindi retained an older feature in *pāñch*. Comparing both descendants reveals the history that either one alone could hide.

The letters in this word

Both write चार, but Marathi pronounces च before *ā* nearer **ts**: *tsār*. The letters stayed aligned while the sound moved.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the borrowed rhyme — *tiṇṇi ... donṇi*
- innovation — Marathi *don*’s final *n*
- retention — Hindi *pāñch*’s nasal
- same spelling, shifted sound — *chār* / *tsār*

Before you move on

Did Marathi *don* preserve an ancient ending? (No: *two* copied *three*.) Which language retains Sanskrit *pañca*’s nasal in writing? (Hindi.) Why can neither daughter be called simply older? (Each changed or retained a different feature.) What does Marathi change without respelling चार? (*Ch* shifts toward *ts* before *ā*.)

Chapter 7

The Core Verbs

7.1 असणे (asṇe) — “to be,” and the word your sentence ends on

You have already said it: *mājhami nāv ... āhe*. Now meet the verb that form belongs to, and notice where Marathi insists on putting it.

You’ll want to know: असणे and its present आहे

असणे — *asṇe* — to be

The ending -णे (-ṇe) is the Marathi infinitive, the same ending as *bolṇe* “to speak.” Its present tense is short, irregular, and already yours: आहे (*āhe*) — “am, is, are.”

who	Marathi	said
मी (I)	आहे	<i>āhe</i>
तू (you, familiar)	आहेस	<i>āhes</i>
तुम्ही (you, respectful)	आहात	<i>āhāt</i>

The letters in this word

अ is the bare vowel *a*; स is *sa*; णे is the retroflex ण *ṇa* carrying the -*e* stroke — *a-sa-ṇe*. आ is that first letter with an upright stroke added, the long *ā*. हे is ह *ha* with the same -*e* stroke: *ā-he*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Sanskrit’s word for “is” was अस्ति *ásti*, sitting on the stem *as-*, and that stem goes back to the Indo-European root ***h₁es-**. It surfaces almost everywhere the family reaches: Latin *est*, Greek *estí*, German *ist*, and English **is**. *Asṇe* is built straight on it.

आहे itself is the contested piece. Some trace it to *ásti* directly; others route it through a Middle Indo-Aryan verb *acchai* “stays, remains.” The family is not in doubt, the exact line of descent is — so treat it as an open question rather than a settled fact.

Grammar Lens: the sentence ends on आहे

English slots *is* into the middle of a sentence: “My name **is** Sara.” Marathi holds it back to the very end:

माझं नाव सारा आहे — *mājhami nāv Sārā āhe* — piece by piece, “my name Sara is.”

That is the rule for every Marathi verb, and *āhe* is where it becomes unmissable. Whatever else the sentence carries, the verb closes it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “asṇe” — to be — then its present, “āhe”
- the three persons — “mī āhe ... tū āhes ... tumhī āhāt”
- your own name in Marathi order — “mājhami nāv ... āhe”

Before you move on

What is the infinitive behind *āhe*? (असणे, *asṇe*.) Where does a Marathi verb stand? (**Last** — the sentence closes on it.) Which everyday English word is *ásti*’s own cousin? (**Is**.) Next: a verb that changes shape according to who is speaking.

7.2 जाणे (jāṇe) — “to go,” and a present tense that gives you away

Say “my name is ...” once more, and hear where *āhe* lands. Every verb from here obeys that same rule. This one adds a second rule English has no use for.

You’ll want to know: जाणे

जाणे — *jāṇe* — to go

Strip the infinitive ending -णे and the stem is जा- *jā-*. On that stem Marathi builds the everyday present: जातो (*jāto*) and जाते (*jāte*).

Both mean “I go.” Neither is more correct than the other. Which one you may say is decided by something the English sentence never mentions.

The letters in this word

ज is *ja*, and the upright stroke after it is the long *ā* — together जा *jā*. णे you met last lesson: retroflex ण with the -*e* stroke. Two syllables, *jā-ṇe*, with the tongue curled back for that second one.

Grammar Lens: the ending declares who is speaking

English “I go” hides the speaker completely — a man and a woman say the same two words. Marathi will not let you:

speaking of	Marathi	said
a man, of himself	मी जातो	<i>mī jāto</i>
a woman, of herself	मी जाते	<i>mī jāte</i>
a man, “he goes”	तो जातो	<i>to jāto</i>
a woman, “she goes”	ती जाते	<i>tī jāte</i>

The -तो / -ते swap is the whole mechanism, and it runs through every verb: *bolto* / *bolte*, *yetto* / *yete*. Hindi marks gender on its verbs too, but Marathi makes it unavoidable in the plainest sentence a beginner can build. From your first “I go,” you are choosing.

Notice also what is missing: no separate word for “am.” The ending carries the action, the person, and the gender at once.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “jāṇe” — to go — then the stem, “jā-”
- “I go” in your own gender — “mī jāto” or “mī jāte”
- the pair — “to jāto ... tī jāte”

Before you move on

What is the stem inside *jāṇe*? (जा-, *jā-*.) Which two endings split the present, and by what? (-तो / -ते, by the gender of the one the verb is about.) Can a Marathi speaker say “I go” without revealing it? (**No** — the choice is forced.) Next: the same ancient root, pointed the other way.

7.3 येणे (yeṇe) — “to come,” the other half of “to go”

Say “I go” in your own gender: *mī jāto* or *mī jāte*. Hold that shape. The next verb is closer to it than it sounds.

You’ll want to know: येणे

येणे — *yeṇe* — **to come**

Same infinitive ending, same machinery: stem ये- *ye-*, present येतो (*yeto*) and येते (*yete*), split by gender exactly as *jāto* / *jāte* was.

You met *yeto* in Chapter 1 as a farewell — Marathi takes its leave by saying “I come,” promising the return rather than announcing the departure.

The letters in this word

य is *ya*, a soft English *y* as in *yes*. Add the *-e* stroke above and you have ये *ye* — the same stroke you have been putting on णे and on हे in *āhe*. Two syllables: *ye-ṇe*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Sanskrit had a verb of travelling, **yā-**, whose present was **याति** *yāti* “goes, travels.” Middle Indo-Aryan turned that initial *y-* into a *j-*, giving Prakrit *jāi* — and that is Marathi **जाणे**.

Now put a prefix on it. Sanskrit **आ-** *ā-* means “toward, hither,” and **आयाति** *āyāti* is “travels toward here” — that is, **comes**. Worn down through the same centuries, *āyāti* is Marathi **येणे**.

So *going* and *coming* are not two verbs in this family. They are one verb of travelling, and the only difference is a prefix meaning “this way.” English keeps a faint echo of the same trick in *go* against *in-coming*, but it needs two separate roots to do what Sanskrit did with one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “येणे” — to come — then the stem, “ye-”
- “I come” in your own gender — “mī yeto” or “mī yete”
- the derivation — “yāti ... āyāti ... येणे”

Before you move on

What is the stem of *येणे*? (ये-, ye-.) Which Sanskrit root do *jāṇe* and *येणे* share? (यā-, to travel.) What single piece turns going into coming? (The prefix आ- ā-, “toward here.”) Next: an infinitive that is also a noun, and the gender Hindi does not have.

7.4 खाणे (khāṇe) — “to eat,” and Marathi’s third gender

Two infinitives so far: *jāṇe*, *येणे*. Say them. This third one is ordinary as a verb and quietly remarkable as a noun.

You’ll want to know: खाणे

खाणे — *khāṇe* — to eat

Stem खा- *khā-*, present खातो (*khāto*) and खाते (*khāte*) on the gendered pattern you already have.

Its root is Sanskrit खादति *khādati*, “chews, eats” — a solidly Indo-Aryan word with no borrowing in its history. The *-d-* wore away on the road to Marathi; the long *ā* stayed.

The letters in this word

ख is *kha* — a *k* with a genuine puff of breath after it, the sound in English *kit* said hard, not the *k* of *skit*. Marathi treats that puff as a different letter, not an accent. Add the long-*ā* stroke and the familiar णे: *khā-ṇe*.

Grammar Lens: the infinitive is a neuter noun

खाणे also simply means “eating” — the thing, not the act of doing it. Every -णे infinitive works this way; खाणंपिणं (*khāṇaṁ-piṇaṁ*), “eating and drinking,” is how Marathi says food and drink.

And as a noun it carries a gender — **neuter**, the third one. Hindi has two genders, masculine and feminine. Marathi kept all three that Sanskrit had, so words agreeing with a noun come in three shapes:

gender	“good”	said
masculine	चांगला	<i>chāṅglā</i>
feminine	चांगली	<i>chāṅglī</i>
neuter	चांगलं	<i>chāṅglam</i>

So “eating is good” is खाणं चांगलं आहे — *khāṇaṁ chāṅglam āhe*, with the neuter ending twice over and the verb, as always, last.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “khāṇe” — to eat — then “I eat” in your own gender
- the three shapes — “chāṅglā ... chāṅglī ... chāṅglam”
- “eating is good” — “khāṇaṁ chāṅglam āhe”

Before you move on

What are the two things खाणे means? (**To eat**, and **eating** as a noun.) How many genders does Marathi have, and how many does Hindi have? (**Three** against **two** — Marathi kept Sanskrit’s neuter.) Which gender is an infinitive? (**Neuter**.) Next: a verb whose root you already own in a dozen English words.

7.5 पाहणे (pāhṇe) — “to see,” a root you already own

Say “I eat” in your own gender — *mī khāto* or *mī khāte*. The next verb runs on the same endings, and on a root you have been using in English all your life without knowing it.

You’ll want to know: पाहणे

पाहणे — *pāhṇe* — to see, to watch

Stem पाह- *pāh-*, present पाहतो (*pāhto*) and पाहते (*pāhte*). In everyday speech you will also hear बघणे (*baghṇe*) for the same job; *pāhṇe* is the one whose history repays digging.

The letters in this word

प is *pa* without the puff of breath that *kha* had. Add the upright stroke for long *ā*: पा *pā*. Then ह *ha*, and the णे you now know by heart. Three light syllables, *pā-ha-ṇe*, usually spoken as two: *pāh-ṇe*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Sanskrit’s verb for seeing was पश्यति *paśyati*, on the root *paś-*, and Marathi’s *pāhṇe* descends from its prefixed form प्रपश्यति *prapaśyati*, “looks out at.”

Now the payoff. That *paś-* is the Indo-European root ***spek-**, “to observe.” Sanskrit dropped the *s-* and swapped the consonants around; Latin kept them in order as *speciō*, “I look.” From the Latin side English inherited an enormous family, every one of them a cousin of *pāhṇe*: **spectacle**, **inspect**, **respect**, **suspect**, **prospect**, **species**, **specimen**, **speculate**, **telescope**, and — through Italian — **spy**.

So a Marathi speaker asking you to *pāhṇe* something is asking you to *inspect* it, in the most literal ancestral sense the word has.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pāhṇe” — to see — then “I see” in your own gender
- the derivation — “paśyati ... prapaśyati ... pāhṇe”
- four English cousins — “spectacle, inspect, species, spy”

Before you move on

What is the stem of *pāhṇe*? (पाह-, *pāh-*.) Which Sanskrit verb is it from? (पश्यति *paśyati*, in its prefixed form *prapaśyati*.) Name three English words from the same ancient root. (*Spectacle, inspect, species, spy* — any three.) Next: a verb Marathi mostly refuses to use, and what it says instead.

7.6 माहीत असणे (māhīt asṇe) — “to know,” which Marathi says sideways

Say “I go” and “I come” in your own gender — *jāto* or *jāte*, *yeto* or *yete*. Five verbs obeyed that pattern. This one refuses.

You’ll want to know: माहीत असणे and जाणणे

माहीत असणे — *māhīt asṇe* — **to know** (everyday)

जाणणे — *jāṇṇe* — **to know** (formal, literary)

Marathi has an inherited verb for knowing and barely uses it. Everyday speech says *māhīt asṇe*, “to be known,” built on *asṇe*.

The letters in this word

म is *ma*; with the long-*ā* stroke, मा. ही is ह *ha* with the long -*ī* stroke, which leans forward ahead of its letter. त is *ta*: *mā-hī-t*.

Grammar Lens: knowledge comes to you, you do not do it

मला माहीत आहे — *malā māhīt āhe* — “I know.”

Word by word: “**to me** known **is**.” *Malā* is “to me,” and the knower sits there, not in the subject slot. Nobody acts; a fact is simply in your possession, and *āhe* closes the line.

The same frame carries a language: मला मराठी येते — *malā marāṭhī yete* — “I know Marathi,” literally “to me Marathi comes.” *Yete* is feminine because the subject is मराठी, a feminine noun — not the speaker; a man says it too. The verb agrees with its subject, as always. Here the subject is not you.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

माहीत is a **loan**: through Persian from Arabic *māhiyat*, “the particulars” — one of the administrative words the Deccan sultanates left in Marathi.

जाणणे is pure inheritance: Sanskrit जानाति *jānāti*, root *jñā-*, from Indo-European ***gnō-** — the root of English **know**, Latin *nōscere* (*notice, recognize*) and Greek *gnōsis* (*diagnosis*). Marathi kept the cousin and gave the daily work to the loan.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*malā māhīt āhe*” — then literally, “to me known is”
- “I know Marathi” — “*malā marāṭhī yete*”
- the inherited verb and its English cousin — “*jāṇṇe ... know*”

Before you move on

Where does Marathi put the knower? (**In the dative** — *malā*, “to me.”) Which verb finishes *malā māhīt āhe*, and where? (आहे, **last**.) Why *yete* in *malā marāṭhī yete*? (The subject is मराठी, feminine — agreeing with it, not the speaker.) Which know-verb was borrowed? (माहीत, through Persian.)

Devanagari for Marathi — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words. This page gathers the system, and flags what is special about *Marathi's* Devanagari.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** क ka, न na, म ma.
2. **A vowel sign (*mātrā*) changes it:** का k̄a, कि k̄i, की k̄ī, कु ku, के ke, को ko, कौ kau.
3. **A *halant* removes it,** and the bare consonant joins the next as a conjunct: स् + का → स्का; न् + य → न्य. The *anusvāra* dot ँ nasalises a vowel (बरं *barṇ*).

What is special about Marathi's Devanagari

- **The extra letter ऌ (*ḷa*)** — a **retroflex l**, made with the tongue curled back. Hindi does *not* have it; Marathi shares it with the Dravidian languages to the south (Tamil *ḷ*, Kannada, etc.), a mark of centuries of contact. It appears in common words like *kāḷ* (“time”) and *phāḷ* (“fruit”).
- **The vowel अँ / ऐँ** for the English “a” of *cat* — added for English loanwords (*baṅk*, “bank”).
- **Three genders.** Marathi keeps Sanskrit's masculine, feminine, *and* neuter, where Hindi collapsed to two — and it marks gender on verbs and adjectives more thoroughly than Hindi.

Marathi in the family

Marathi is **Indo-Aryan** (like Hindi, Punjabi, Bengali — descended from Sanskrit), spoken in Maharashtra. Its Devanagari and much of its formal vocabulary are shared with Hindi and Sanskrit; its sound system, its extra letter $\overline{\text{अ}}$, and parts of its grammar bear the imprint of long contact with Dravidian. The lessons trace both threads.